Of course, we were imperfect. Of course, there were moments of tension. Jonathan Trott flew at Matty Prior when he criticized a mistake in the field. ‘Don’t you ever speak to me like that again!’ he yelled. ‘Well, you’re fucking fielding for England, mate,’ Prior replied. They had a stand-up row, sorted out their differences like adults and moved on immediately.

As captain I was comfortable with allowing senior players their head in the dressing room. These people cared. It is not a place for tra-la-la innocence. No one walks in trilling, ‘Morning, everyone. What a wonderful day.’ Mockery is delivered on a give-and-take basis. Nicknames, such as ‘Cheese’, which Prior picked up at Sussex, tend to stick.

Flower inherited chaos, and imposed order with greater sensitivity than his authoritarian image suggests. I enjoyed working with him, even though things ended badly. I’m happy to march behind anyone who possesses the cojones to call out Robert Mugabe as the man who ruined Zimbabwe, Andy’s country. That takes a rare form of moral courage. The stability he brought gave us the extra 2 per cent that is so often decisive. He strengthened the bubble, acted as a doorkeeper to our world. Andy might not have been as good at empowering players as someone like Trevor Bayliss, who is skilful in fostering a spirit of independence, but I valued his directness, shrewdness and honesty.

The relationship between captain and coach is pivotal. Each must be comfortable with his role and responsibilities. Differences, in terms of selection strategies or training plans, can be dealt with if there is mutual trust and respect, but ultimately the coach is there to support the captain. Andy was the perfect guide in my early days, because he managed my workload and allowed me to concentrate on my game. As I grew stronger as a leader, I knew I needed to take greater responsibility.

We all develop. Andy didn’t like grey areas, and if you spoke to him today he would perhaps accept he could have been a better listener. He admitted to me recently that, given his time again, he would still coach the player, but pay more attention to coaching the person. On one thing he cannot be challenged, however: he helped to maximize talent and developed a team through his willingness to confront difficult issues. His skill as a coach was to ask uncomfortable questions of his players.

All too often such questions go unasked. They prompt awkward silences but are never designed to belittle the individual. Singling someone out in front of twelve or fifteen of his peers is the worst thing you can do, as a